



Presence practices for everyday life

Small pauses that bring you back to yourself, in the middle of the chaos.

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*This guide is a self-knowledge and
well-being resource. It does not
replace therapeutic support.*

1. Why you live on autopilot

There is a question I often ask the women I accompany, one that almost always provokes the same reaction: a silence followed by wet eyes.

The question is this: "When was the last time you were entirely present in a moment? Not thinking about what still needs to be done. Not planning the next step. Not ruminating on what happened yesterday. Entirely here, in what was happening?"

Most can't remember. Or remember a moment so distant it seems to belong to another life. And it's not because they are distracted people, or neglectful, or insufficiently spiritual. It's because they live lives that don't allow for presence.

Think about your day. You wake (often before you want to) and your first gesture is to reach for your phone. Before you even feel your body, you're already reading messages, checking emails, absorbing information. The day begins without you. It begins with the world entering before you have come out of yourself.

Then comes the routine: getting dressed, preparing, feeding, driving, working, solving, responding, caring. A sequence of actions that link together without pauses, without intervals, without breathing. And you execute. With competence, often with excellence. But without being there. Your body acts, your mind is already on the next step. You're feeding your child breakfast and thinking about the ten o'clock meeting. You're at the meeting thinking about dinner. You're preparing dinner and thinking about what you didn't do today. You're lying in bed thinking about tomorrow. You're never where you are.

This has a name: autopilot. And it's the mode most of us live in most of the time. Not by choice. By necessity. Because life demands so much, so quickly, so constantly, that the only way to get through everything is to switch off presence and switch on execution.

And it works. In the short term, it works wonderfully. You can do more, in less time, with less apparent effort. But the price is enormous. Because when you live on autopilot, you don't live. You function. And there is an enormous difference between functioning and living.

Functioning is the body moving without you inside it. Living is being inside your body as it moves. Functioning is seeing the sunset and thinking "it's beautiful" without feeling anything. Living is seeing the sunset and feeling your chest open. Functioning is embracing your child

and already thinking about the next task. Living is embracing your child and feeling their warmth, their weight, their scent, and in that instant needing nothing more.

Autopilot steals your life without you noticing. It doesn't steal your years (you are alive, the years pass). It steals your experience of the years. It steals the moments. It steals the texture of the day. And when you look back, what you see is a sequence of things done, but not felt. A list of tasks completed, but not lived.

And there comes a moment when you realize: I was here, but I wasn't really here. My children grew and I was looking at my phone. The years passed and I was running from one thing to another. Life happened and I was planning life.

If this touches you, it's not your fault. It's not a lack of attention. It's not a lack of discipline. It's the result of a culture that tells us the value of a person is measured by what they produce, not by what they feel. That being busy is a virtue and being still is laziness. That presence is a luxury for those who "have time." And since no one has time (or thinks they don't), presence is put off until later. And later never comes.

And there is one consequence of autopilot that is rarely discussed: the loss of emotional memory. Not memory of facts (you remember what happened), but memory of how you felt. You may remember that your child had a birthday, but you don't remember the feeling of singing happy birthday to them. You may remember going on vacation, but what you feel when you think about those holidays is vague, faded, like a photograph left in the sun too long. Life happened. But you weren't present enough to feel it. And when you look back, what you find are facts without emotion. Scenes without color. A biography on paper that should be full of life but that seems strangely flat.

And there is something else: autopilot doesn't only affect your experience. It affects the people around you. Your children feel when you're not there. Not consciously, perhaps. But their bodies know. They know the difference between a mother who is present and a mother who is functioning. And that difference marks them. Not through trauma. Through absence. Through that subtle feeling that "mum is here but isn't really here."

And your partner feels it too. The dinner conversation that isn't a conversation, it's an exchange of logistical information. The goodnight kiss that's a gesture, not contact. Physical closeness without emotional closeness. Everything functions. But no one meets.

This guide is an invitation for "later" to be now. Not with big changes, not with hours of meditation, not with spiritual retreats. With small pauses. Small interruptions in the autopilot. Small moments in which you remember to come back to yourself.

2. What presence is (without mysticism)

Before I give you the practices, I need to clarify one thing: presence is not meditation. It's not mindfulness in the sense that magazines sell. It's not sitting cross-legged trying to "empty your mind" (which, incidentally, is nearly impossible and generates more frustration than peace). It's not a special state only Buddhist monks achieve. It's not esoteric.

Presence is, simply, being here. Now. With what is. Without adding anything (thoughts about the past, worries about the future). Without subtracting anything (the emotion you feel, the sensation in your body, the sound you hear). Just being.

It sounds simple. And it is. But simple is not easy. Because the mind has been trained for decades to be everywhere except here. The mind loves the past (to ruminate) and the future (to worry about). The present, for the mind, is boring. It has no drama. It has no story. It has only what is. And "what is," in most moments, is profoundly simple: the weight of your body in the chair, the sound of rain, the warmth of the cup in your hand, the breath going in and out.

But in that simplicity lives something the agitated mind never finds: peace. Not the peace of holidays (which is temporary and depends on circumstances). The peace of being in contact with the moment, as it is, without needing it to be different.

And there is one thing neuroscience has shown us in recent years: presence literally changes the brain. Regular practice of moments of full attention reduces the activity of the amygdala (the center of fear and stress), increases the thickness of the prefrontal cortex (responsible for emotional regulation and decision-making), and improves connectivity between different brain regions. It's not mysticism. It's biology. And it works.

But you don't need to know any of this in order to practice. All you need is to remember, from time to time throughout the day, to come back. Come back to the body. Come back to the moment. Come back to yourself.

3. 7 presence practices for your day

These practices are not complicated exercises. They are pauses. Small pauses you can fit into your day without changing anything in your routine. You don't need extra time. You need attention.

I want to be honest: I'm not going to give you a list of twenty-minute meditations. Not because long meditations aren't valuable (they are). But because I know that if I ask you for twenty minutes, you probably won't do it. Not because you don't want to. Because it doesn't fit. And this guide is for your real life, not the ideal life that wellness magazines describe.

What I offer you are seven micro-practices. None of them takes more than a minute. Some take seconds. But each one is an interruption in the autopilot. A way of reminding your body and your mind: I am here. I am alive. This moment exists. And I am inside it.

1. The first conscious breath

When you wake, before picking up your phone, before getting up, before thinking about the list for the day, do one thing: breathe. One breath. Slowly. Deeply. Feel the air entering. Feel the chest expanding.

Feel the air leaving. Just one breath. It takes perhaps ten seconds. But those ten seconds change the way you begin the day. Because instead of beginning with the world (the messages, the news, the demands), you begin with yourself.

2. The five senses pause

At any moment during the day (in the supermarket queue, waiting for the water to boil, in the car stopped in traffic), take a pause and notice: one thing you see, one you hear, one you feel on your skin, one you smell, one you taste in your mouth. It takes thirty seconds. And what it does is bring you back to the body. Because the senses don't live in the past or the future. They live only in the now.

3. Hands in the water

When you wash your hands (and you wash them many times a day), feel the water. Don't think about the water. Feel it. The temperature, the texture, the sound. Let your hands be the only place where your attention rests. Twenty seconds. And in that time, you were entirely present.

4. The first sip

When you drink your first cup of coffee or tea of the day, drink the first sip with complete attention. Feel the warmth in your mouth. Feel the taste. Feel your throat receiving it. One sip. Not a Japanese tea ceremony. One sip. But one whole sip, with all your presence.

5. The touch of your child

When you touch your child (when hugging, taking their hand, adjusting their clothes), feel the touch. Not as an automatic gesture. As contact. Feel the warmth of their skin. The weight of their body. The softness of their hair. Three seconds of real contact are worth more than an hour of distracted presence. And your child feels the difference. Children know when you're truly there and when you're only present in body.

There is an experience I do with mothers who come to me that is always revealing. I ask them to hug their child for thirty seconds, in silence, without saying anything, just feeling. It sounds simple. But almost all of them begin to cry. Not from sadness. From recognition. From realizing how much time they spent hugging in passing, in a rush, as a formality. And from feeling, in those thirty seconds, everything

they had been missing. You don't need to have thirty special seconds. You just need your regular hugs to be real. Instead of hugging while already thinking about what comes next, hug while feeling what is here.

6. The sigh stop

Two or three times during the day, wherever you are, stop and sigh. A deep, audible, complete sigh. Not a sigh of tiredness. A sigh of release. The sigh is the fastest way to activate the parasympathetic nervous system (the system that calms). When you sigh, the body receives a signal: everything is fine. You can relax. And in that instant of relaxation, presence returns.

7. The bedtime ritual

Before falling asleep, lie down and feel your body in the bed. Not like someone who lies down thinking about the day. Like someone who lies down to feel. The weight on your back. The texture of the sheets. The warmth or coolness of the air. And thank your body for another day. Not with grand words. With simple recognition: "Thank you, body. You made it through another day." And fall asleep from that place, rather than from the list of worries.

4. How to fit this into a full day

I know what you're thinking: "Vivianne, you don't know my day." And you're right, I don't. But I know full days. I have three children. I have work. I have commitments, deadlines, responsibilities. And I still find these pauses. Not because I have more time than you. Because they're not about time. They're about attention.

None of these practices requires extra time. The morning breath takes ten seconds. The five senses pause takes thirty. Hands in the water happens in a moment that already exists. The coffee sip happens in a gesture you already make. The touch of your child happens in a hug you already give. The sigh needs no scheduling. The bedtime ritual replaces scrolling on your phone, it doesn't add anything to the day.

What these practices require is remembering. Remembering that, in the middle of everything, you can come back to yourself. For a moment. And that moment is already enough.

It can help to choose just one practice and do it for a week. Not all of them at once. One. The one that makes the most sense to you, the one that seems easiest to fit into your routine. And when that one is integra-

ted (when you already do it without thinking), add another. And another. And gradually, without noticing, your day begins to have small oases of presence amid the desert of agitation.

Another thing that helps: linking the practices to triggers that already exist. The morning breath links to the moment of waking (trigger: opening your eyes). Hands in the water link to each bathroom visit (trigger: turning on the tap). The coffee sip links to the morning ritual (trigger: the first cup). When you link a new practice to a habit you already have, the probability of remembering increases enormously. You don't depend on memory. You depend on routine. And routine, which is normally the enemy of presence, becomes your ally.

And there's a trick I learned from a mother I know: she put a small colored dot on her car clock. Every time she looked at the time (which happened many times a day), the dot reminded her to breathe. One second. One breath. And her day, which was exactly as full as before, came to have dozens of micro-moments of presence scattered throughout.

And there is something surprising that many women report when they practice these pauses regularly: they don't end up with less time. They end up with more. Because presence brings efficiency. When you're entirely in what you're doing, you do it faster and better. Distraction is what wastes time. Presence saves it.

And there's another thing: presence is contagious. When you're present with your children, they calm down. When you're present with your partner, the conversation has more depth. When you're present at work, decisions are clearer. Presence isn't a luxury. It's the foundation of everything you do well.

And if you miss a day? If you spend the whole day on autopilot and only remember these practices at bedtime? No problem. Do the bedtime ritual. Or simply notice: "Today I wasn't present." Without judgment. Without guilt. Without the dramatic promise that "tomorrow will be different." Just the note. Because even that note, that brief instant of awareness, is already presence. It's already a moment when you stepped out of the automatic and looked at yourself. And that moment counts.

Presence is not a goal to be reached. It's a practice to be practiced. Every day. Some days better, others worse. But every time you come back, you come back. And every time you come back, the way back gets shorter.

5. The place of presence in your life

If you feel these practices help you, if you feel these small pauses bring you back to yourself, I want you to know there is more. Not more in the sense of more exercises or more techniques. More in the sense of more depth.

Presence is a door. When you open it, even for moments, you glimpse something on the other side: a different relationship with yourself, with your body, with your children, with the world. A relationship not based on functioning, but on existing.

Loranne is the space I created for those who want to go deeper into this practice. Not as meditation training. As a way of being in the world. Through music, silence, sound, attention to what is. Find it at music.seteveus.space.

And if what these pauses show you is that you need something more (more space for yourself, more inner work, more accompaniment), the other spaces are there: the [Escola dos Véus](#) for deep self-knowledge, [Infonte](#) for creativity as a path of reconnection, [FreeMe](#) for those who need to free themselves from family patterns.

But for now, the invitation is simple: come back. Come back to your body. Come back to the moment. Come back to yourself. One breath at a time.

This guide is a self-knowledge and well-being resource. It does not constitute therapeutic or psychological advice. If you feel you live in persistent disconnection, emotional exhaustion, or if your symptoms are more than ordinary distraction, seek professional support.

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